

Chapter 1 — Introduction

1.1 Background and Context

Employee training is central to the work of a bank. Employees must keep pace with changes in digital systems, products, internal processes, customer service practices, risk controls, and regulatory requirements. A training programme is useful only when employees can access the material, understand it, participate in the learning process, and use the learning in relevant work situations. This makes the design and delivery of training an important human-resource issue, rather than a matter of attendance alone.

Digital learning has changed how organisations can provide training. A digital platform can make modules, reading material, short videos, assessments, virtual sessions, and job aids available to employees across locations. It can help employees return to material when they need revision and can make common information available at a consistent standard. These benefits are especially useful for a geographically distributed organisation such as a bank. However, access to digital content does not by itself show that employees understand it or can apply it. Employees may find a module difficult to locate, may encounter technical problems, may complete a module without engaging with it, or may need a trainer to explain how a new procedure applies to their work.

Face-to-face learning continues to have a role in employee development. A trainer-led session can be used for explanation, discussion, demonstration, role play, case analysis, feedback, and practice. Employees can raise questions and learn from colleagues who have faced similar work situations. This does not mean that every learning activity should take place in a classroom. Basic information, pre-reading, refresher content, short assessments, and reference material may be suitable for a digital platform. The important issue is whether the digital and face-to-face parts are planned as connected learning activities, with each part serving a clear purpose.

Hybrid learning, also called blended learning, is the planned combination of digital and face-to-face learning within the same programme. The value of hybrid learning lies in its integration. A digital activity can prepare employees for a trainer-led session. The trainer-led session can then help employees interpret, practise, and apply the material. Digital content can later reinforce the learning and provide a resource for revision. When these activities are not connected, employees may experience the programme as a collection of unrelated requirements. The presence of two delivery modes alone is therefore not enough to establish a meaningful hybrid-learning experience.

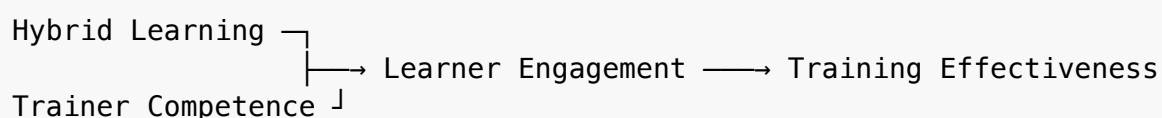
In a well-designed programme, the two modes have complementary functions rather than duplicate the same content. Digital learning may be used for preparation, reference material, short knowledge checks, and later revision. Trainer-led sessions may then be used for discussion, demonstration, practice, feedback, and clarification in relation to work situations. The appropriate sequence will depend on the training objective; the study does not assume that one fixed balance or sequence is suitable for every banking programme.

The present study is located at Union Bank of India, with planned data collection among eligible employees connected with Regional Office Chennai South in Royapettah, Chennai. Union Bank has documented a substantial learning and development system. Its 2023–24 annual report identifies Union Vidya as the Bank's Learning Management System and describes digital resources such as e-books,

podcasts and audiobooks, social-learning platforms, microlearning modules, and virtual workshops. The 2024–25 report describes a learning-and-development policy that includes e-learning, virtual training, and staggered programmes. It also records mandatory e-learning modules for officers, role-based training, and a Training Management System within Union Vidya (Union Bank of India, 2024, 2025). These documented arrangements make the setting suitable for a study of how employees experience connected digital and face-to-face learning. They do not show that every programme uses the same platform, content, or balance of learning modes. The study therefore asks employees to consider one recent programme in which both modes were used.

The study considers four constructs. Hybrid Learning refers to the quality of the connected digital and face-to-face learning experience. It includes integration of activities, access to the platform, availability of learning materials, and opportunities to revisit digital content. Trainer Competence refers to the trainer's subject knowledge, clarity, ability to connect learning activities, capability in using relevant digital tools, encouragement of participation, and feedback. Learner Engagement refers to the employee's attention, effort, interest, participation, and willingness to seek clarification during the programme. Training Effectiveness refers to the employee's perception that the programme produced understandable, relevant, useful, and applicable learning for the employee's work.

The proposed model is:



The model does not claim that one survey can prove a causal sequence. It is used to examine whether employees who report more positive Hybrid Learning and Trainer Competence also report higher Learner Engagement, and whether employees who report higher engagement also report more effective training. The study uses employee perceptions because employees are the people who complete modules, attend sessions, interact with trainers, and decide whether they can use the learning in their work. At the same time, these perceptions are not treated as a substitute for supervisor assessments, examination scores, audit records, customer information, or organisation-level performance data.

Three complementary base papers support the study. Sosnova et al. (2025) is the guide-suggested conceptual anchor. In a higher-education experiment, the authors examined whether hybrid education methods were associated with improved learning effectiveness. The population differs from the present study, but the paper supports the basic proposition that the relationship between learning modes and learning outcomes deserves examination. Kim (2022) provides the corporate anchor. The study compared traditional, fully digital, and hybrid sales-training delivery in a South Korean automotive setting and examined training effectiveness through its Content, Instructional Design, Programmed Learning, and Recommendation framework. Bahl, Kiran and Sharma (2024) provide the banking anchor. Their open-access study evaluated training among 402 employees from Indian public, private, and foreign-sector banks using Kirkpatrick's Reaction, Learning, Behaviour, and Results framework. Bahl does not examine Hybrid Learning, Trainer Competence, or Learner Engagement, which makes the present Union Bank model a focused extension rather than a reproduction of that study. Together, the three papers provide conceptual, corporate, and banking evidence for examining employee training effectiveness.

The study is relevant to human-resource management because training design affects the employee's experience of learning. If digital and face-to-face activities are connected poorly, employees may view training as an additional compliance task. If a trainer cannot explain the purpose of the activities or respond to questions, employees may not participate fully. If employees are engaged and see a programme as useful, they may be more likely to understand and apply what is taught. The study can therefore provide evidence for practical decisions about learning design, trainer preparation, employee participation, and the use of Union Vidya or similar digital learning platforms.

1.2 Key Concepts and Definitions

Hybrid Learning

Hybrid Learning is the purposeful combination of digital and face-to-face learning within one training programme. The two modes are not separate alternatives. They are designed to support each other. In an employee-training context, the digital component may include an LMS module, video, online assessment, virtual session, downloadable reference material, or short refresher. The face-to-face component may include a classroom session, demonstration, case discussion, role play, group exercise, or supervised practice.

In this study, Hybrid Learning is an employee-perception construct. It is measured through the employee's view of whether the digital and face-to-face activities formed one connected programme, whether the platform and materials were accessible, and whether the digital material could be revisited when required. The study does not evaluate Union Vidya as a technology product, compare separate online-only and classroom-only programmes, or prescribe one fixed ratio between digital and face-to-face learning.

Trainer Competence

Trainer Competence refers to the trainer's ability to support employee learning. It includes knowledge of the subject, clear explanation, ability to organise or use relevant digital tools, ability to explain the connection between learning activities, encouragement of participation, and provision of useful feedback. In a hybrid programme, trainer competence matters across both modes. Employees may need a trainer to explain why a digital module comes before a session, how a task will be discussed later, or how a process applies in a real work situation.

Trainer Competence is treated as a separate construct rather than as a feature of Hybrid Learning. A programme may use an accessible platform and still be less effective if the trainer cannot explain the content or encourage participation. Separating the two constructs allows the study to examine their distinct relationships with Learner Engagement.

Learner Engagement

Learner Engagement is the employee's active involvement in the training process. It includes attention, effort to understand the content, participation in activities, interest in completing the programme, and seeking clarification where necessary. Engagement is more than attendance or course completion. An employee can be present in a classroom or logged into a digital platform without concentrating on the content. Conversely, an engaged employee makes an effort to understand, participates in discussion or practice, and asks questions when the material is unclear.

The present study measures engagement as an employee's reported learning behaviour during one selected hybrid-training programme. It does not measure general work engagement, employee commitment, metacognitive skill, or motivation as separate variables.

Training Effectiveness

Training Effectiveness is the extent to which employees believe that a programme produced useful learning for their work. It includes understanding the main knowledge or skill taught, seeing its relevance to the current role, feeling capable of using it, applying it in day-to-day work, dealing with related tasks more effectively, and having greater confidence in relevant responsibilities.

The definition is informed by training-evaluation and training-transfer literature. It moves beyond immediate satisfaction, but it remains within the limits of self-reported employee data. The study does not claim to measure organisational productivity, reputation, customer satisfaction, business results, or an objective change in an individual's performance.

Learning Management System

A Learning Management System, or LMS, is a digital system used to organise, deliver, monitor, or support learning. It may host modules, reading material, video, quizzes, virtual sessions, announcements, and learning records. Union Bank identifies Union Vidya as its LMS and reports that the platform sits within a wider system of e-learning, virtual training, staggered programmes, and role-based learning (Union Bank of India, 2024, 2025). In the present study, the LMS is part of the Hybrid Learning context. The questionnaire refers to the digital platform used for the selected programme and names Union Vidya only as an example. This avoids assuming that all programmes use the same system or that all respondents encounter identical platform features.

1.3 Need, Scope and Significance of the Study

Need for the study

The practical need for the study arises from a straightforward question: when employees attend a training programme that combines digital and face-to-face learning, how do the design of the programme and the competence of the trainer relate to their engagement and their view of training effectiveness? This question matters because the delivery of training can shape whether employees treat learning as useful work support or as a disconnected requirement.

Existing research supports the importance of the question but leaves a context gap. A substantial part of blended-learning research uses school or university populations. Those studies are useful for understanding the design of integrated learning environments, but employees learn under different conditions. They must balance work demands, customer responsibilities, operational deadlines, and changing systems. Corporate evidence is available, yet there is limited verified evidence on the relationship between hybrid learning, trainer competence, learner engagement, and training effectiveness among employees of an Indian public-sector bank.

Union Bank of India provides a suitable organisational context because it has a documented digital learning system and broader training infrastructure. Public reporting establishes that the Bank uses digital and trainer-led learning resources. It does not show how employees experience a particular hybrid programme. The present study focuses on that narrower and more appropriate employee-level question.

Scope of the study

The study is limited to employees connected with Union Bank of India Regional Office Chennai South who have attended at least one programme in the previous 12 months that combined digital and face-to-face learning. Respondents answer with reference to one recent programme. Employees who have attended only a digital programme or only a face-to-face programme are not eligible because they cannot assess the integration of the two learning modes.

The study examines Hybrid Learning, Trainer Competence, Learner Engagement, and Training Effectiveness. It does not treat knowledge retention, job performance, organisation-level results, supervisor support, employee agility, digital literacy, or the technical performance of an LMS as separate variables. These matters may be relevant to training in general, but including them would make the survey and analysis too broad for the proposed sample.

The research uses a structured five-point agreement questionnaire. It is quantitative, descriptive, correlational, and cross-sectional. The findings describe the selected respondent group and relationships among their reported perceptions. They cannot establish that the training programme caused later changes in work behaviour or bank performance.

Significance of the study

For Union Bank of India, the study may provide structured employee feedback on the connection between digital and face-to-face learning, the role of trainer support, and the conditions that help employees engage with a programme. The findings may help identify areas for practical attention, such as the sequencing of digital modules, access to learning resources, clarity of trainer guidance, feedback, or opportunities for participation.

For trainers and learning-and-development staff, the study highlights that a training programme involves more than content delivery. A trainer may need to connect pre-learning material with later discussion, explain why an activity matters, encourage questions, and make feedback available across learning modes. These are practical behaviours that can be improved through trainer preparation and programme design.

For academic research, the study contributes evidence from an underrepresented public-sector banking context. It combines a guide-suggested conceptual study, corporate training evidence, and a workplace engagement model, while using a short, transparent, literature-informed questionnaire. It does not present the instrument as a ready-made Union Bank scale. Instead, it documents the evidence basis for each construct and proposes reliability and content-validity checks before the main survey.

1.4 Statement of the Problem

Union Bank of India has a documented learning and development system that includes digital learning resources and trainer-led training activity. These facilities create the possibility of hybrid learning. However, the availability of a platform and training programmes does not show whether employees experience digital and face-to-face activities as a connected learning journey, whether trainers support that connection effectively, or whether employees engage sufficiently to obtain useful learning from the programme.

The problem addressed by this study is the limited verified evidence on the relationships among Hybrid Learning, Trainer Competence, Learner Engagement, and Training Effectiveness among employees of Union Bank of India. Existing studies provide useful evidence from higher education, general corporate settings, and other workplace contexts. They do not directly address the selected public-sector banking setting or the Union Vidya/LMS context.

The study therefore examines whether more positive employee perceptions of Hybrid Learning and Trainer Competence are associated with higher Learner Engagement, and whether higher Learner Engagement is associated with greater Training Effectiveness.

1.5 Industry and Company Context

Banks operate in a setting where work practices change regularly. Employees may need to understand a new digital feature, updated policy, revised compliance requirement, product detail, procedure, or customer-service practice. Training must be available to employees working across locations and roles, while still allowing questions, examples, and practice. This makes a connected hybrid approach potentially useful, provided the programme is designed carefully and is appropriate to the learning objective.

The study does not assume that all banking topics need the same delivery approach. A mandatory policy update may require a short digital module and assessment. A process change may require digital pre-learning followed by a trainer-led demonstration and practice. A customer-interaction topic may require discussion and role play. The value of hybrid learning lies in matching the activity to the learning need and linking the activities clearly.

Union Bank of India is a public-sector bank with a large workforce and an established learning and development function. The Bank's annual reports describe Union Vidya as its LMS and place it alongside digital resources, e-learning, virtual training, staggered programmes, role-based modules, and trainer-led learning activity (Union Bank of India, 2024, 2025). These reports provide the organisational context for the study. They are not treated as evidence that every employee experiences every feature, that every programme is hybrid, or that the platform works identically for all staff.

The empirical focus is deliberately narrow: eligible employees connected with Regional Office Chennai South and their experience of one recent hybrid-training programme. This keeps the study grounded in the actual respondent experience and avoids unsupported claims about the entire Bank or Indian banking sector.

1.6 Chapterization

Chapter 1 introduces the study, defines the four constructs, explains the need and scope, and states the problem in the Union Bank of India context.

Chapter 2 reviews the literature on Hybrid Learning, Trainer Competence, Learner Engagement, and Training Effectiveness. It explains the role of the three base papers, presents the theoretical framework, and identifies the workplace, banking, LMS, and measurement gaps addressed by the study.

Chapter 3 presents the research methodology, objectives, relationship hypotheses, definitions of variables, sample approach, data-collection procedure, questionnaire design, and analysis plan.

Chapter 4 will report actual survey findings only after data collection. It will contain an illustrative template until that time.

Chapter 5 will discuss conclusions and recommendations after real data analysis. It will remain an illustrative template until that time.

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